

Virtual Proving Ground for RainForest Climate Strategies

Test consequences before equipment sees a command

64 scheduled controls

36 climate channels

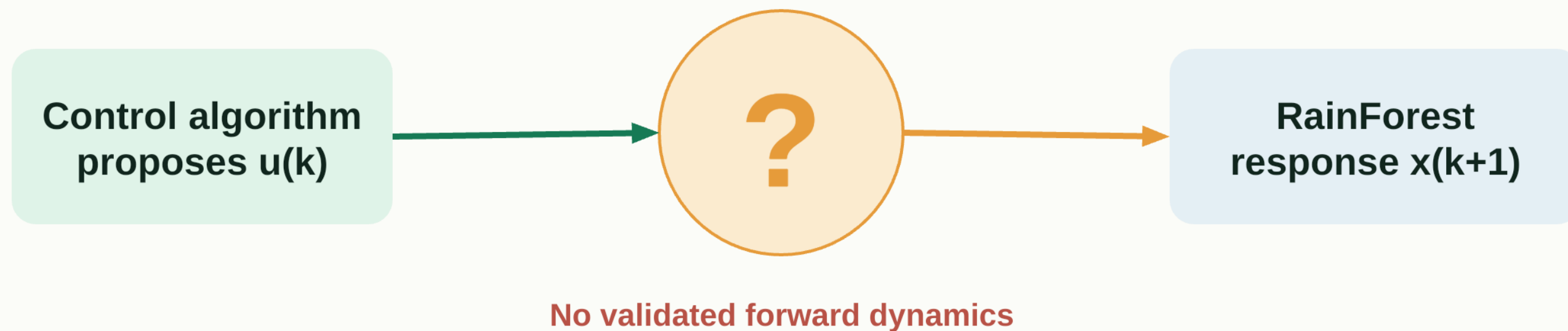
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Optimal control without validated dynamics

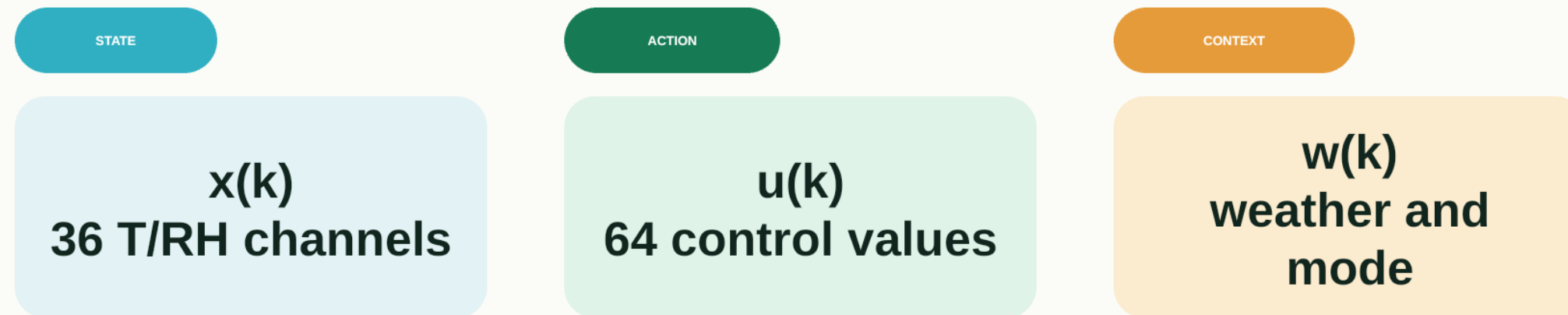
A proposed strategy has no defensible meaning until its consequences can be estimated



**Mathematical optimization can produce a schedule.
Without validated dynamics, the schedule has no defensible operational
meaning.**

The missing forward model

Dynamics connect a 64-value action to the next 36-channel climate state



$$x(k+1) = F\theta(x(k), u(k), w(k))$$

Then evaluate climate deviation, energy use, equipment wear, and hard constraints

$F\theta$ remains a replaceable and validated module

Operational risk of direct experimentation

The RainForest is an environmental system with little tolerance for uncontrolled trials

26

**air handlers support
the facility**

about 20

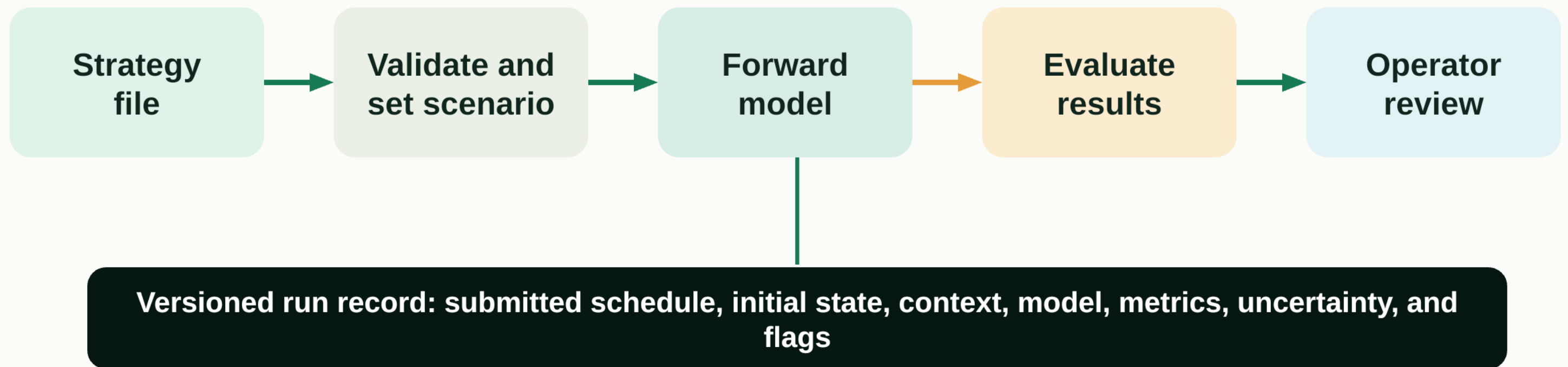
**minutes before a sunny-day
power loss could irreparably
damage biomes**

**Delayed climate
response
plus coupled
equipment
requires conservative
testing**

Facility context from Biosphere 2. The figures describe environmental support, not algorithm-specific risk.

Virtual Proving Ground architecture

One evaluation loop separates strategy authors from facility equipment



The platform tests externally created strategies. It does not generate or rewrite them.

Climate strategy contract

A strategy is a timestamped sequence of complete commands

timestamp

complete absolute control vector

08:00

$u(1) = [u_0, u_1, \dots, u_{63}]$

10:00

$u(2) = [u_0, u_1, \dots, u_{63}]$

12:00

$u(3) = [u_0, u_1, \dots, u_{63}]$

14:00

$u(4) = [u_0, u_1, \dots, u_{63}]$

16:00

$u(5) = [u_0, u_1, \dots, u_{63}]$

15
setpoints

7
fans

42
valves and
dampers

JSON or CSV / units /
bounds / monotone
timestamps / no missing
controls

Illustrative interface demonstration

The current app demonstrates the evaluation workflow, not a validated prediction



35-second interface replay



[Open live demo](#)

Illustrative scenario
not yet model-generated

Reading the simulation output

A useful result explains trajectory, uncertainty, and the reason for each flag



- 36-channel spatial trajectory
- Selected sensor time series
- Comfort and safety envelope
- Energy and stability indicators
- Uncertainty and diagnostic reason

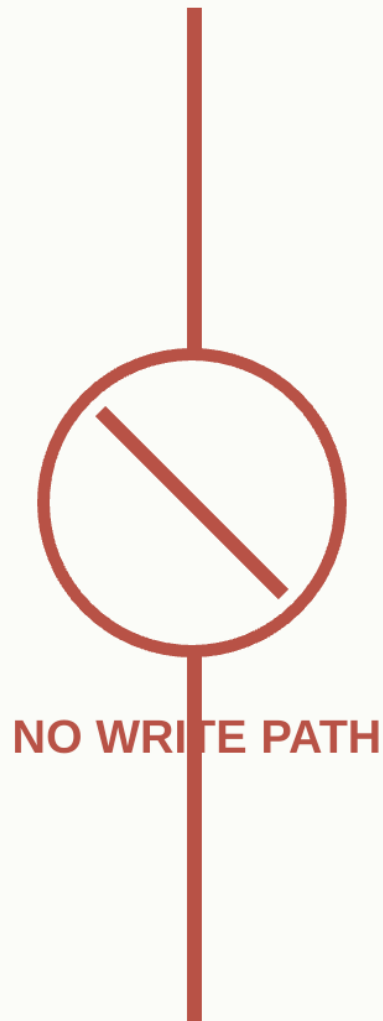
Every warning traces to a channel, timestamp, threshold, and submitted control schedule

Human approval and operational boundaries

The first phase remains offline and advisory

Research environment

- Upload strategy
- Simulate and score
- Preserve run record



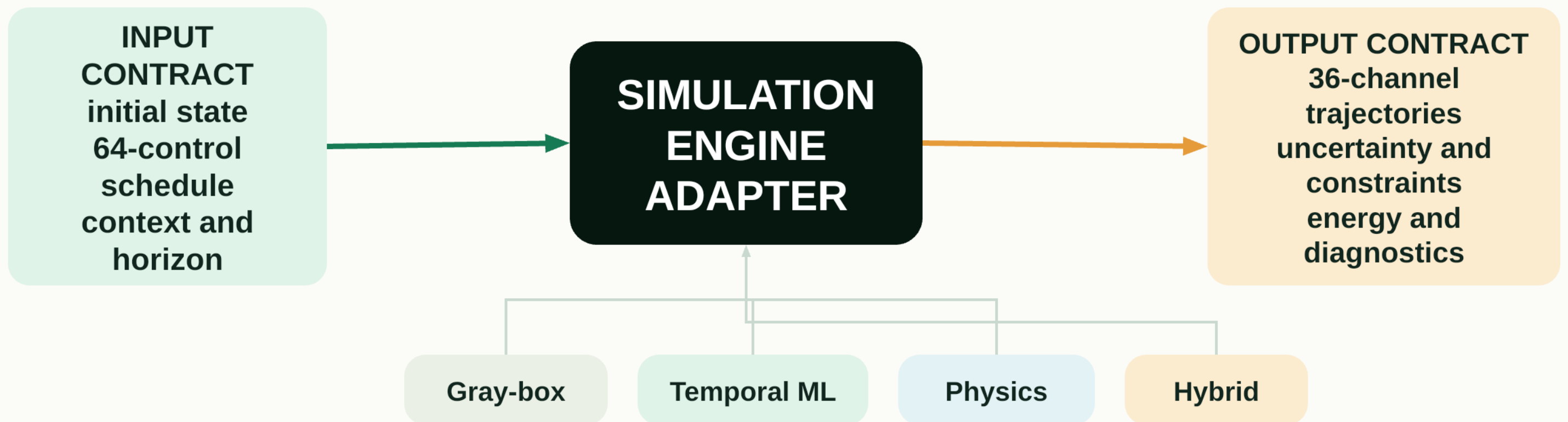
Biosphere 2 operations

- Review evidence
- Approve any future protocol
- Retain stop authority

A prediction supports a decision. It does not grant operational authority.

Pluggable simulation engine

A stable contract allows models to improve without rebuilding the platform



The same strategy and scenario can be compared across engines

Candidate forward-model families

The PoC should benchmark complementary approaches

GRAY-BOX

Interpretable dynamics

Modest data need

May miss nonlinear coupling

simple and legible

TEMPORAL ML

Learns delays and nonlinear response

Fast repeated simulation

Needs coverage and OOD checks

flexible surrogate

PHYSICS

Explicit HVAC and energy structure

Transparent assumptions

Calibration can be labor intensive

component fidelity

HYBRID

Physical constraints plus learned residual

Balances structure and fit

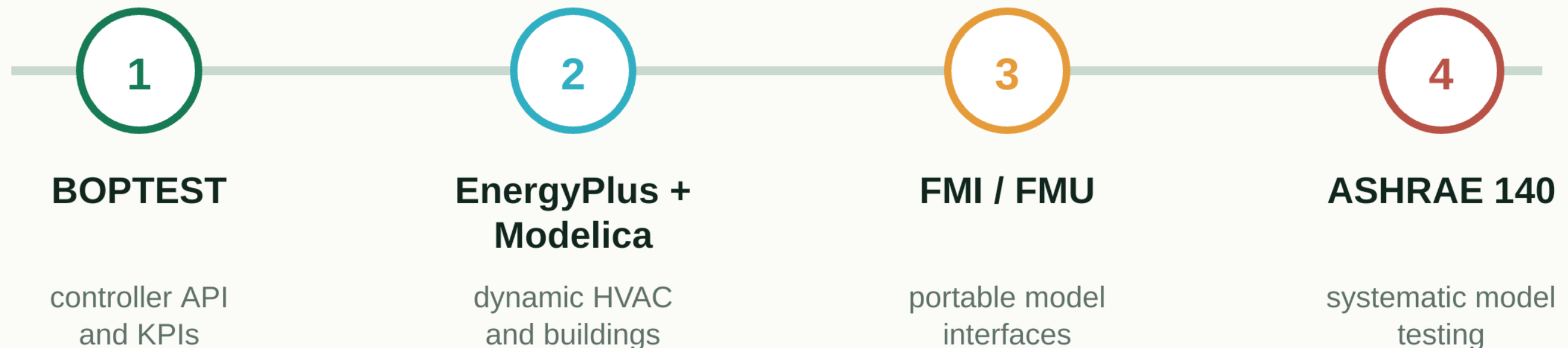
More integration complexity

candidate end state

Select the simplest engine that passes the agreed validation gates

Established simulation foundations

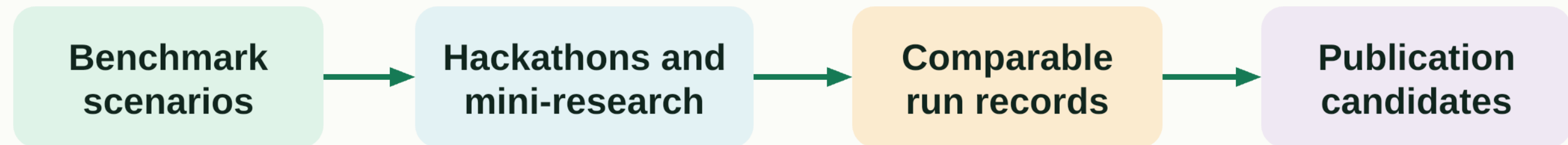
The proposal applies mature testing patterns to a unique biome



These references support the engineering pattern. They do not certify the present app or remove RainForest-specific calibration.

Student competition and research pipeline

A common simulator turns broad participation into comparable evidence



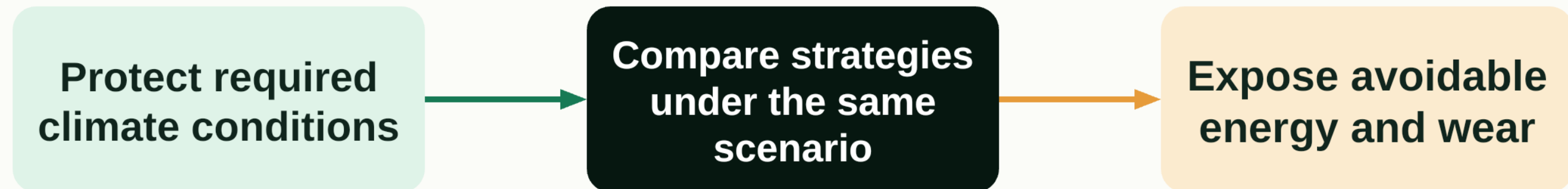
- PID, MPC, RL, and new methods share one external strategy contract
- Students never need access to the operational network
- Faculty can compare results because datasets, baselines, metrics, and model versions are preserved

Operational and economic value

Better evidence can reduce waste while protecting climate performance

Major energy-cost-saving potential

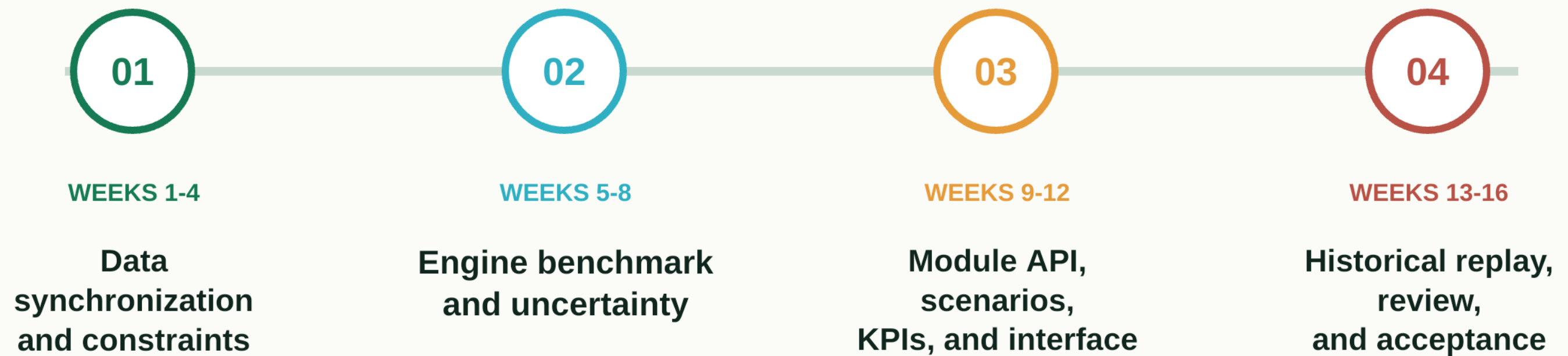
requires calibrated evidence before a percentage or dollar claim



Operational planning / focused field trials / grant evidence / reusable research benchmarks

Sixteen-week Proof of Concept

The PoC ends with an evidence-based decision on Phase 2



Exit package: offline testbed, validation report, limitations, and Phase 2 recommendation

Decision requested

Approve a scoped offline PoC with operational access and review

Approve the 16-week offline Proof of Concept

- Assign a Biosphere 2 operations liaison
- Authorize synchronized control, climate, weather, energy, and constraint data
- Review acceptance evidence before any Phase 2 or field trial



Live illustrative interface

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Current assets and honest limitations

A useful foundation exists, but the causal simulator remains PoC work

AVAILABLE NOW

- 64-control inventory
- 36-channel measurement schema
- Data-pipeline code
- Timestamped strategy contract
- Working illustrative 3D interface

POC WORK

- Synchronized causal dataset
- Validated and versioned engine
- Uncertainty and unsupported-region checks
- Energy indicators and operating constraints
- Historical replay and operator acceptance

No survey-grade CAD, E57 conversion, equipment write access, or autonomous control in this phase

Required data and validation gates

Accuracy claims require aligned histories and protected holdout periods

REQUIRED EVIDENCE

- Commands + actual actuator states
- T/RH + quality flags
- Weather + operating modes
- Energy or equipment power
- Maintenance and schedule events



VALIDATION GATE

ACCEPTANCE CHECKS

- Chronological holdout periods
- Error by channel and horizon
- Constraint-event detection
- Uncertainty calibration
- Reject unsupported scenarios

Data alignment is the first technical risk

Q&A: accuracy and observability

Prediction quality must be reported by use case, horizon, and operating region

01 How accurate must the simulator be?

Use-case thresholds. Report error by channel, horizon, season, and operating region.

02 What if sensors are missing or unreliable?

Flag degraded operation. Reject the run or widen uncertainty when evidence is insufficient.

03 How will causal response be validated?

Align controls, actuator states, context, and protected chronological holdout periods.

Full answers appear in the speaker notes and companion script

Q&A: safety and operational authority

Simulation evidence supports operators and does not bypass them

04 Could the simulator damage equipment?

No. The PoC has no write path to equipment.

05 Who authorizes a field trial?

Biosphere 2 operations retains authority for every field trial.

06 How is cybersecurity handled?

Use offline copies, least privilege, versioning, and network separation.

Full answers appear in the speaker notes and companion script

Q&A: model and platform choices

The contract stays stable while evidence determines the engine

07 Why not use EnergyPlus alone?

EnergyPlus still needs RainForest-specific representation, calibration, and validation.

08 Why consider an LSTM?

An LSTM can learn delayed nonlinear behavior, but it must pass coverage and uncertainty checks.

09 How can a new engine be added?

A common input/output contract and adapters isolate every engine.

Full answers appear in the speaker notes and companion script

Q&A: value and schedule

The PoC measures whether a larger investment is justified

10 How will energy savings be proven?

Calibrate energy indicators, then validate them against an approved operational baseline.

11 What resources does the PoC require?

Authorized data, an operations liaison, implementation time, and ordinary compute.

12 Why sixteen weeks?

Four stages cover data, models, platform integration, and operator-reviewed validation.

Full answers appear in the speaker notes and companion script

Q&A: students, publications, and governance

Participation expands only after benchmark and review rules are stable

13 **How is student code isolated?**

Student code runs offline in isolated environments, never on the operational network.

14 **How are publications, data rights, and IP governed?**

Written University and Biosphere 2 rules govern data, review, authorship, and IP.

15 **Who owns and maintains the platform?**

Phase 2 needs an operational owner, technical maintainer, and release process.

Full answers appear in the speaker notes and companion script

References and live demonstration

Authoritative foundations and project resources

Biosphere 2

biosphere2.org/about/about-biosphere-2

Biosphere 2 energy and water

biosphere2.org/research/user-facility-information/energy-and-water

BOPTEST

ibpsa.github.io/project1-boptest

EnergyPlus

energyplus.net

Modelica Buildings Library

simulationresearch.lbl.gov/modelica

Functional Mock-up Interface

fmi-standard.org

ASHRAE Standard 140

data.ashrae.org/standard140



LIVE ILLUSTRATIVE DEMO

rainforest-virtual-proving-ground.dimitribolt.chatgpt.site

Project sources: DigitalTwin control and sensor inventories, data-pipeline code, and current interface source